

Is Another Movement to Overthrow Capital Possible in the 21st Century?

Zhihu

To speak plainly, the Chinese may not want to hear it, but what must come will come, independent of anyone's will.

Not so long ago, Fukuyama looked upon the collapsing socialist countries and put forward the "end of history". The socialist experiment was over; history had ended in capitalism, and revolution, the planned economy, class struggle — all of it — vanished into the eternal heaven of the free market and representative democracy.

This current of thought chimed in neatly with changes inside China. For a group of old men who had fought their way out of a mountain of corpses and a sea of blood had also, to the strains of the Internationale, "bid farewell to revolution". Through the long primary stage, capital was not merely left standing; it was welcomed into the hall, holding forth on the CCTV evening news and representing the people in the legislature.

In such circumstances, does it not seem a little ridiculous to talk of "overthrowing capital"? Should some tactless fellow come running up shouting slogans, people would ask him instead: do you really want to live through those hungry days? We can oblige you — the Land of Light next door, the Caribbean island: one of them is bound to suit you.

Zhuangzi said: "You cannot speak to a summer insect about ice — it is bound to its season." This describes China's anti-"anti-capital" people rather well. One must understand the summer insect's limitations, and wait patiently for it to evolve to the point where it can live until winter. To force the summer insect to grasp the merits of ice, or even to argue with it over whether ice is cold or hot, is the unreasonable course.

When China was founded, proletarians were few: counting even waiters and rickshaw pullers, they were under 10 per cent of the population. The industrial base was weaker still — the textbooks say it was comparable to Belgium, but in steel and electricity it lagged far behind Belgium. The society built in such a country you may call socialist; its relations of production were indeed public or collective ownership. Yet for the daily life of the great majority of working people, it remained a long way from the standard of a socialist society.

A famous man from Guang'an once said, "Poverty is not socialism." The anti-capital people detest this sarcastic-tongued figure, but one has to admit that the phrase struck a chord among the masses.

The superiority of socialism rests on the foundation of an industrial society. Bear in mind that only in 1990 did China's per-capita electricity generation reach the level of the United States in 1925. And in the 1960s, when the whole land was "a single red", most families had no electricity at all.

We have no wish to deny the Herculean efforts of our predecessors. But to understand the masses' rejection of and fear towards the "anti-capital movement", we must recognise that the socialist society in our memory was one under construction, not one completed. Most of those who lived through the red years never truly experienced a socialist society.

So when we discuss the decay of capitalism and call for overthrowing capital and building socialism, what reappears in the minds of these old-timers is not the dreamlike scene of workers managing the factories and freely associated people governing society, but going hungry in the mountain villages and buying rice with ration coupons in the cities.

"You cannot speak to a summer insect about ice" — but the trouble is that someone once pointed at a puddle and told the summer insect, "that is ice". Of course, when winter comes and the ground freezes, that puddle is turned by nature's uncanny craft into clear, translucent ice.

To this swarm of summer insects, water is ice; and so ice is not cold — it even burns. Ask them about using ice to escape the heat, and they will accuse you of spreading demagogic lies.

Yet, summer insect! Time passes, the seasons turn; high summer must end, and deep winter will surely come. If your limbs are strong enough to live until that freezing season, you will see that what I say is no lie.

Winter is still far off, and this swarm of summer insects will most likely not live to see that season. Still, we can already feel the end of summer. The direction has been broken off, the days drag on, but the autumn wind is blowing in, slowly. We know that a mighty force governs the turning of the solar terms.

From the EU to the US, the cry of "overthrow capital" is rising^{[1][2]}

Thirty years later^{[3][4]}

By then, if any summer insect is still alive and can glimpse real ice, what a marvellous sensation that will be. May we all be lucky enough to witness and take part in a great transformation of the age.

Notes

^[1] The Prospects of Reformism

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<https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/2082185310675407388>

[2] In the 2026 Berlin parliamentary election, the far-left party Die Linke led other parties by a wide margin — how should this be assessed?

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<https://www.zhihu.com/question/2085199171422774582/answer/2086802500997457869>

[3] Understanding the Capitalist Long Wave in Depth

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<https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/2069764635574720379>

[4] The Rise of the Dragon click "Download the raw file"

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https://github.com/sacanlee/capitalist_world_system_analysis-repo/blob/main/articles/Chinese/world-system-mechanisms/%E9%BE%99%E7%9A%84%E5%B4%9B%E8%B5%B7%EF%BC%9A%E8%B5%84%E6%9C%AC%E4%B8%BB%E4%B9%89%E4%B8%96%E7%95%8C%E4%BD%93%E7%B3%BB%E4%B8%AD%E7%9A%84%E4%B8%AD%E5%9B%BD.pdf

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